Asian nations such as Cambodia or Laos to oppose stronger criticisms of China's territorial claims in joint ASEAN communiqués.

At times, China's very dominance has worked against it, and Japan has taken advantage of the region's unease at China's power. When ASEAN nations proposed what would become the East Asia Summit in the early 2000s, with the participation of China, Japan, and South Korea, Tokyo successfully lobbied with Singapore for Australia, India, and New Zealand to be included as full members. This inclusion of an additional three democratic nations was designed to blunt China's influence over what was expected to become the largest pan-Asian multilateral initiative and was decried by Chinese media for doing so.

For all their attempts, neither Japan nor China has succeeded in establishing a dominant position as the undisputed great power of Asia. Southeast Asian nations above all want to avoid being drawn into a Sino-Japanese—or, much the same thing, Sino-US-Japan—political and security dispute. The scholars Bhubhindar Singh, Sarah Teo, and Benjamin Ho have argued that, in recent years, ASEAN nations have focused more on the US-China relationship, since it is the United States that has formal Southeast Asian allies and has inserted itself into the South China Sea dispute.[29] Yet all also consider Sino-Japanese ties to be of critical importance for Asian stability in the short and long term. While this particular concern is largely centered on security issues and less on the larger questions of national models, when attention has turned to national development, the focus on China and Japan becomes even clearer. None dismiss the continuing importance of the United States to Asia's short- and medium-term future, but awareness of the long history of Sino-Japanese relations and competition is a primary element of the larger regional perception of power, leadership, and threat that will shape Asia in the coming decades.

It is a truism, though not unhelpful, to observe that neither Japan nor China can leave Asia. They are stuck with each other and with their neighbors, and each has an intense relationship with the United States. Japan and China's economic ties are likely to deepen in future years, even as both look for alternative opportunities as well as seek to